A small guide to the story

New here?

RedNote

Also called Xiaohongshu: a social platform for sharing photos, videos and everyday life.

Community norms

Shared expectations about how people behave and take part.

Cat tax

Sharing cat-related content as a playful contribution. In our cases, it can express welcome, thanks or recognition.

Cat tax is symbolic.
It is not a real tax or an access requirement.

Read the unfolded argument from left to right.

Trend → **Findings** → **Future**

Definitions describe this study's use of the terms

Our focus + the exchanges

Look closer.

[1] Welcome guide
Edited 17 Jan 2025
xhslink.cn/o/8t33exAb76F

[2] Cat-tax exchange
Comment dated 14 Jan 2025
xhslink.cn/o/6RgKjgI4m3m

[3] Gratitude post
Displayed 18 Jan 2025
xhslink.cn/o/2jnaDDQPiQ0

Our topic

Negotiating **community norms** during the January 2025 RedNote influx.

What we examined

A small, selected set of January posts and visible replies about welcome, mutual respect and cat tax.

Expectations were stated.
Contributions were recognised.

Selected exchanges

RedNote / January 2025

Cat tax, shared spaces.



Why did a cat photo become a way to take part?

Unfold: Trend / Findings / Future

Community norms in a cross-border encounter

1 The trend

New platform, new expectations.

US TikTok access uncertainty prompted some users to seek alternatives. Moving to **China's RedNote** brought these newcomers into **direct interaction** with its established, predominantly Chinese-language community.

13 JAN

RedNote tops the US free-app chart.

14 JAN

Reuters reports 700,000+ new users in two days.

18-19 JAN

TikTok briefly interrupts US service, then begins restoring it.

US policy / cross-border migration / everyday interaction

What this illustrates

The January 2025 RedNote influx illustrates an emerging trend of global media: **cross-border platform migration brings users into contact with different community norms.**

700,000 is a reported figure without geographic breakdown

2 The findings

Respect + recognition.

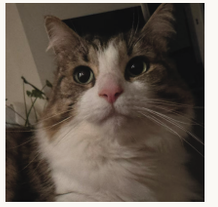
Users negotiated community norms by **stating expectations of mutual respect** and **recognising participation** in shared practices such as "cat tax".

A. An expectation is stated

"Welcome TK Refugees"
"Mutual respect"

Creator's guide, edited 17 January 2025. [1]

B. A contribution is acknowledged



Display photo

In the selected exchange, a **shelter-cat photo** receives "cuteeee" and a **cat-tax receipt**. [2]

Cat Tax Payment Confirmation

兹证明：
This certifies that:

已成功缴纳猫税
has successfully paid the cat tax

Receipt = symbolic recognition, not real account permission

3 The future

Connected, still distinct.

Global connections can bring people together while communities retain different practices.



What this means for global media

The case points towards a future of **interconnected, culturally distinct platform communities**, making the **negotiation of community expectations** a key priority for inclusive cross-border participation.

Who explains expectations?

A case-based implication, not a platform-wide prediction